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DRONES

Defense unicorn Helsing now among Europe's most valuable startups with \$692M raise

By [Leah Hodgson](#)

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Defense tech startup [Helsing](#) has become one of Europe’s most valuable VC-backed companies with a €600 million (about \$692 million) Series D.

The German startup is valued at €12 billion following the round, which was led by [Spotify](#) founder Daniel Ek’s investment company [Prima Materia](#). Additional funds came from investors including [Lightspeed Ventures](#), [Accel](#) and Swedish defense group [Saab](#).

Helsing’s new price tag is more than double the €4.95 billion it attained less than a year ago following a €450 million Series C. At just four years old, the company is now ranked fifth among Europe’s most valuable startups.

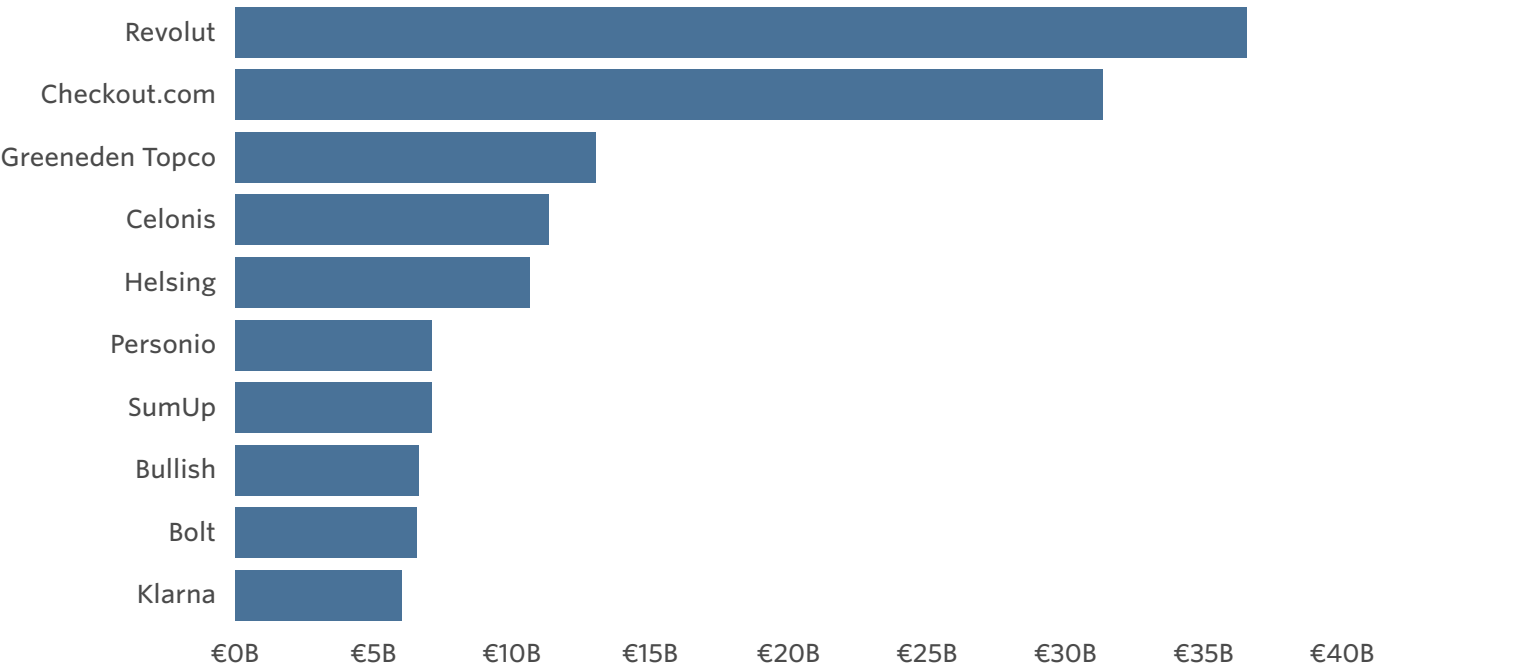
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Europe's most valuable VC-backed companies



Source: PitchBook data
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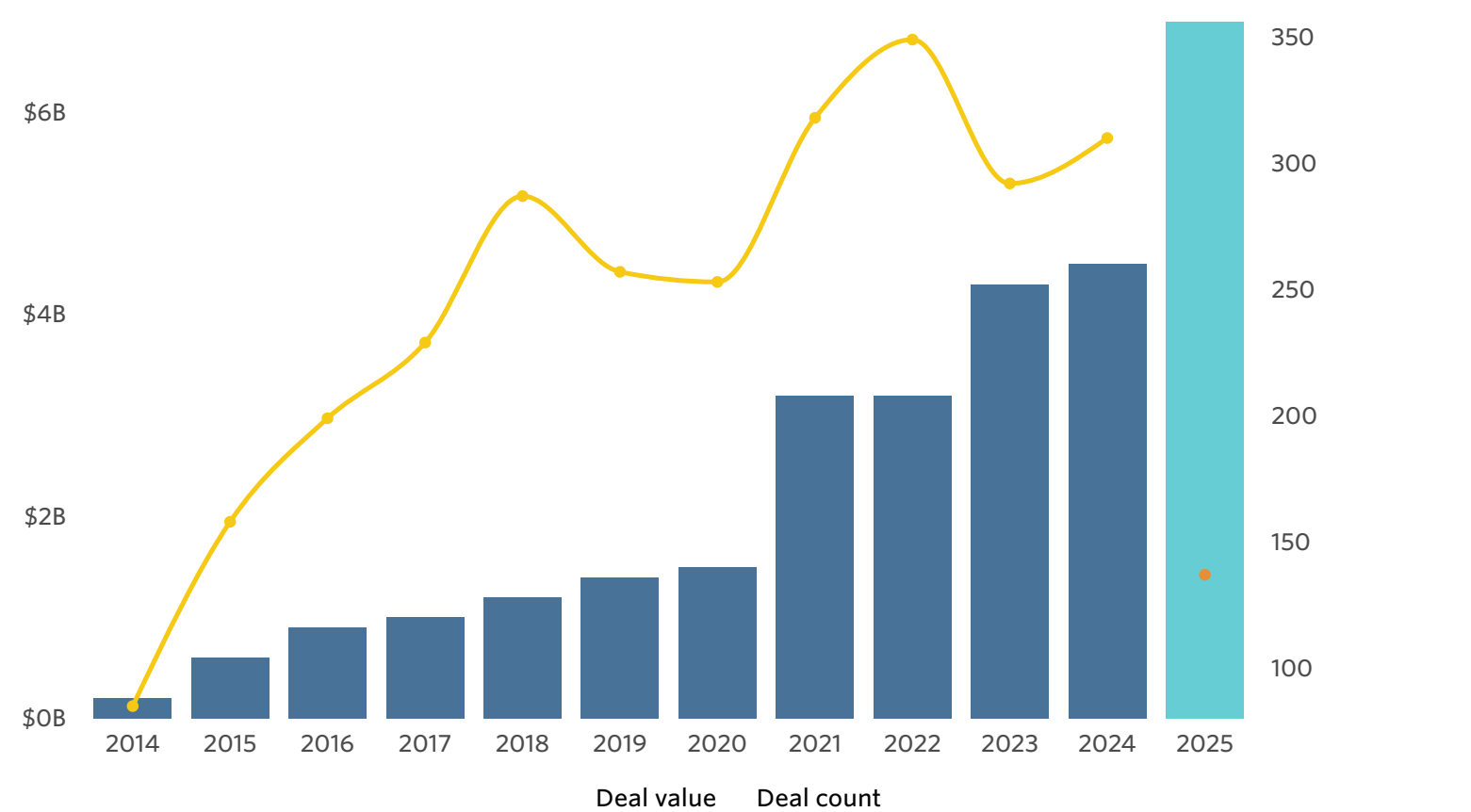
Founded in 2021, Helsing began as a defense software company using AI to create real-time visualizations of battlefields. The company has since expanded its focus to build drones and aircraft. Earlier this month, it agreed to buy German aircraft maker [Grob Aircraft](#) to develop next-gen capabilities for aerial warfare.

Helsing also completed its first factory in Southern Germany this year and aims to produce 6,000 drones for Ukraine. It is also working with [OpenAI](#) rival [Mistral](#) to develop AI defense systems for Europe.

Helsing is benefiting from the boom in investor appetite for defense tech startups, particularly for those developing drones.

According to PitchBook data, VC dealmaking for drone-related companies has shot up this year, reaching \$6.9 billion globally. Deal count is projected to remain relatively flat compared to last year, signalling rising round sizes.

Global VC funding for drones skyrockets



Source: PitchBook data
As of June 17, 2025



The record funding is largely driven by heightened defense needs and shifting military strategies as more conflicts arise worldwide. Modern warfare is increasingly relying on autonomous and unmanned systems, making drones critical assets.

At the same time, drones are becoming vital across sectors such as agriculture, logistics and environmental monitoring, making them a prime example of a dual-use technology that can be used for both military and civilian purposes.

Earlier this year, European drone developers [Quantum Systems](#) and [Tekever](#) **reached unicorn status**. Just a few weeks ago, US-based [Anduril](#) secured \$2.5 billion at a \$30.5 billion valuation.

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About [Leah Hodgson](#)

Leah Hodgson is a London-based senior reporter for PitchBook, covering the venture capital ecosystem across Europe and the Middle East. Leah, who joined PitchBook in 2018, graduated from the University of Surrey with a BA in international politics with French. She has previously been a radio reporter in France. She later turned to financial journalism, covering the wealth management industry.

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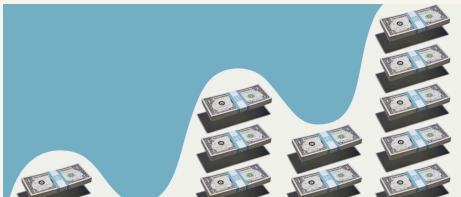


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